



Becoming Big Brother

Setting up a complete surveillance system with all the bells and whistles isn't that difficult a prospect. Here's how to go about getting a professional class system in place with minimal investment.

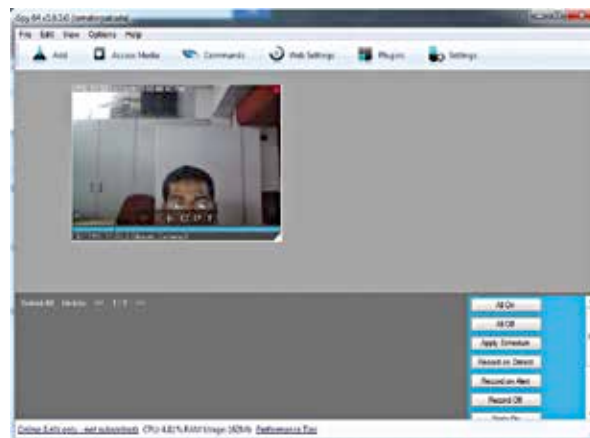
Mithun Mohandas
readersletters@tbindigit.com

While the title might set off alarm bells for some of you folks it isn't that bad an idea to have eyes on everything and everyone all the time. Surveillance is sometimes a necessity and sometimes considered a belligerent action on part of the authority but we're not here to judge. The benefits of having such a system are undoubtedly numerous and we've listed a few scenarios below.

Usage scenarios

Home Surveillance

One simply can't ignore the importance of having an eye on your precious belongings. Keeping a constant eye on your house especially when there are people other than you at home is not only unnecessary but is also perceived as downright paranoid and creepy, however, it might be necessitated if you are a bit suspicious of the person with whom you leave your house in charge (kinda ironic given that you don't trust the person your trusted your house with). Maybe you don't want your house to turn into another "Project X" or you simply want to know if your home has been burgled or which one of your neighbours steals your newspaper. What about when you've entrusted your child with a new nanny? You might want to keep an eye on them for a first few weeks or maybe you're



The main interface is simple and self explanatory

going away for a week and you couldn't find someone to look after your pet.

Office Surveillance

Small offices often tend to be short on an operating budget and hiring an HR team to keep an eye on your work force might not be feasible. In this case, you can not only have an eye on everyone but also monitor each employee's monitor individually. Instead of going in for an expensive professional setup which could set you back by a few lakh rupees you could use an open-source software like we have and get everything done for as low as ₹500.

Hazardous environment

If your work environment is prone to catching fire or your assembly line has a few robots failing every other week then you could have a monitoring

system in place which would detect a lack of movement (indicating stopped machinery) or detect small fires and alert you before it can get big enough to damage your equipment.

Silly stuff

The person who wrote the software we're going to be using wrote it for spotting UFOs and ghosts. We can understand how this

is possible because cameras observe a much wider spectrum of light than humans do and the software is very sensitive even to minor changes in local lighting within a scene. But why do it is a question best left unanswered. Also it could be used for keeping an eye out for local wildlife near a campsite, however, this would be difficult given that there would be a lot of ambient motion in such an area which means your system will be triggered even if a hummingbird flies by.

For this setup we'll be using iSpy

An open-source software which does all the work of analysing each and every camera connected to your system and recording streams once a trigger condition has been satisfied. iSpy has a few plugins available including one for facial recognition and another for number plate